

Camouflage and mimicry

For both predators and prey, camouflage can be a vital weapon in the fight to stay alive. Camouflage helps hunters to get close to their food, but it also protects prey from their predators by making them harder to find. Many animals use camouflage to hide and blend in with their surroundings, but some—called mimics—trick their enemies by imitating dangerous animals or inedible objects. Insects lead the animal world in camouflage defense. Many disguise themselves as twigs, leaves, or flowers, but some imitate other creatures that are armed with poisons or painful stings.

Hornet's yellow and brown markings warn that it is dangerous if attacked



Seeing double

It takes an expert eye to tell a clearwing moth from a hornet.

Both have yellow and brown markings and long transparent wings, and both make a buzzing sound when they fly. However, despite its menacing look, the clearwing moth is harmless—only the real hornet is armed with a sting. This kind of mimicry is a very effective defense, and it has evolved in many different insects. It is also common in small spiders, which often imitate stinging ants.

Arctic fox in winter

Clearwing moth mimics the hornet's color scheme



Changing coats

In the Arctic, dark colors stand out against the snowy landscape, particularly during the winter months. Like many polar mammals, most Arctic foxes replace their brown summer coat with a thicker, white winter coat in the fall, so that they stay camouflaged all year round. The fox's color change is triggered by seasonal differences in day length. These alter hormone levels in the fox's blood, which make it grow a new, furry disguise.



Arctic fox in summer